

THE

**Shibuya
Tokyo
Japan**

TOKYO

TOILET

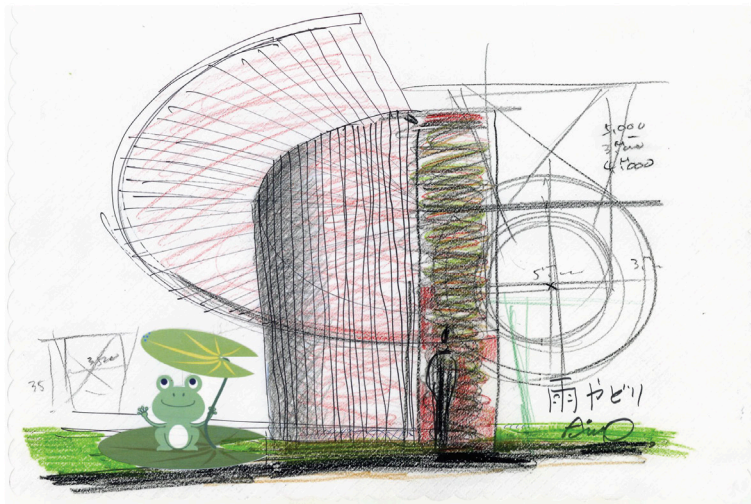


"a symbol of Japan's world-renowned hospitality culture"

THE TOKYO TOILET
by
Astrid Bakke
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Known as one of the cleanest countries in the world, Japan is using the power of design and creativity to propose a new vision for society, changing the stereotype of public toilets as dark, dirty, smelly, and scary.

The Tokyo Toilet, launched in 2020 by The Nippon Foundation and led by Koji Yanai, is an initiative aimed at redefining public restrooms by making them accessible to everyone, regardless of gender, age, or disability. Located in Shibuya, Tokyo, the project has created 17 toilets with the help of top architects and designers and with safety, cleanliness, and inclusivity in mind. Through thoughtful and creative design, these restrooms address social issues while blending functionality with aesthetic appeal. The final toilet was completed and opened to the public in March 2023.





The Nippon Foundation and Koji Yanai

Koji Yanai, driven by a passion to showcase "Japanese pride," envisioned a project that would establish Japanese public toilets as the world's best. Supported by The Nippon Foundation, Asia's leading grantmaker, the initiative collaborates with local governments to embody Japan's spirit of hospitality and cleanliness. Construction was led by Daiwa House Industry Co., Ltd., with TOTO Ltd., Japan's famed toilet manufacturer, providing technical expertise.



Koji Yanai

Shibuya, Tok

All toilets are situated in Shibuya, one of Tokyo's most vibrant districts, renowned for its modern and trendy culture. The project aimed to enhance the usability of public spaces, replacing outdated facilities that lacked accessibility and modern standards. Originally envisioned to impress foreign visitors for the Tokyo 2020 Olympics, but because of the COVID-19 pandemic the games were postponed and there were almost no tourists.





A design that takes advantage of the site's irregular shape. A narrow, triangular site along the railroad tracks.



From left: multi-purpose, men's, and women's

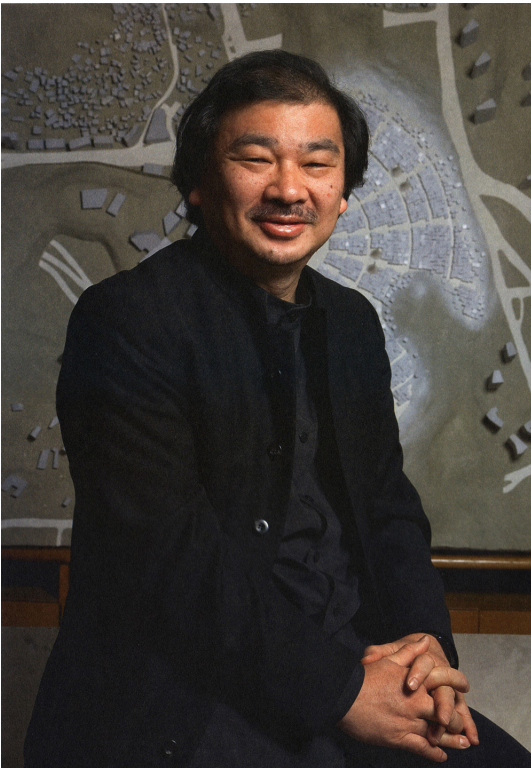
The Designe

The project brought together notable architects of our time including Pritzker Prize winners Tadao Ando, Shigeru Ban and Kengo Kuma. Each contributing not only technical brilliance but also deep philosophical reflections on public space, nature, and humanity.

Shigeru Ban: Trust Through Transparency

At Yoyogi Fukamachi Mini Park and Haru-no-Ogawa Community Park, Shigeru Ban addressed two fundamental concerns surrounding public restrooms: cleanliness and safety. His solution was as imaginative as it was

symbolic. Using smart glass technology, Ban created toilets with transparent walls that become opaque when occupied. This groundbreaking design invites trust through openness, allowing passersby to visually confirm the toilet's cleanliness and security before entering. Ban's colorful, transparent structures dissolve the fear often associated with public facilities, transforming them into welcoming, reassuring spaces that fit harmoniously within the parks' lively environments.



Tadao Ando: Shelter and Serenity

Tadao Ando's design for Jingu-Dori Park reflects his reverence for natural elements and traditional Japanese

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architecture. His circular structure, enclosed by vertical wooden louvers, invites light and air to flow freely, maintaining ventilation while preserving privacy. In a country known for humid summers and sudden rainstorms, Ando's design offers more than shelter it becomes a refuge. The natural materials, simple form, and thoughtful integration with the surrounding cherry trees create a quiet sanctuary where the boundaries between architecture and nature blur. In Ando's vision, even a toilet can be a calming, contemplative place.



Kengo Kuma: Blending Architecture and Nature

Kengo Kuma approached the Nabeshima Shoto Park project with a radically different vision: to make the toilet disappear into nature. Rather than designing a singular structure, Kuma scattered five small wooden huts along a "forest path," crafting an experience of discovery and integration. Using Yoshino cedar and reclaimed woods from old school desks, he emphasized sustainability, craftsmanship, and Japan's profound respect for nature. Each hut serves a different function, celebrating diversity and individuality while maintaining a unified aesthetic harmony. Kuma's "Walk in the Woods" redefines the experience of public toilets, transforming a mundane necessity into an organic, enriching encounter with the landscape.



Transparent Toilets *by Shigeru Ban*



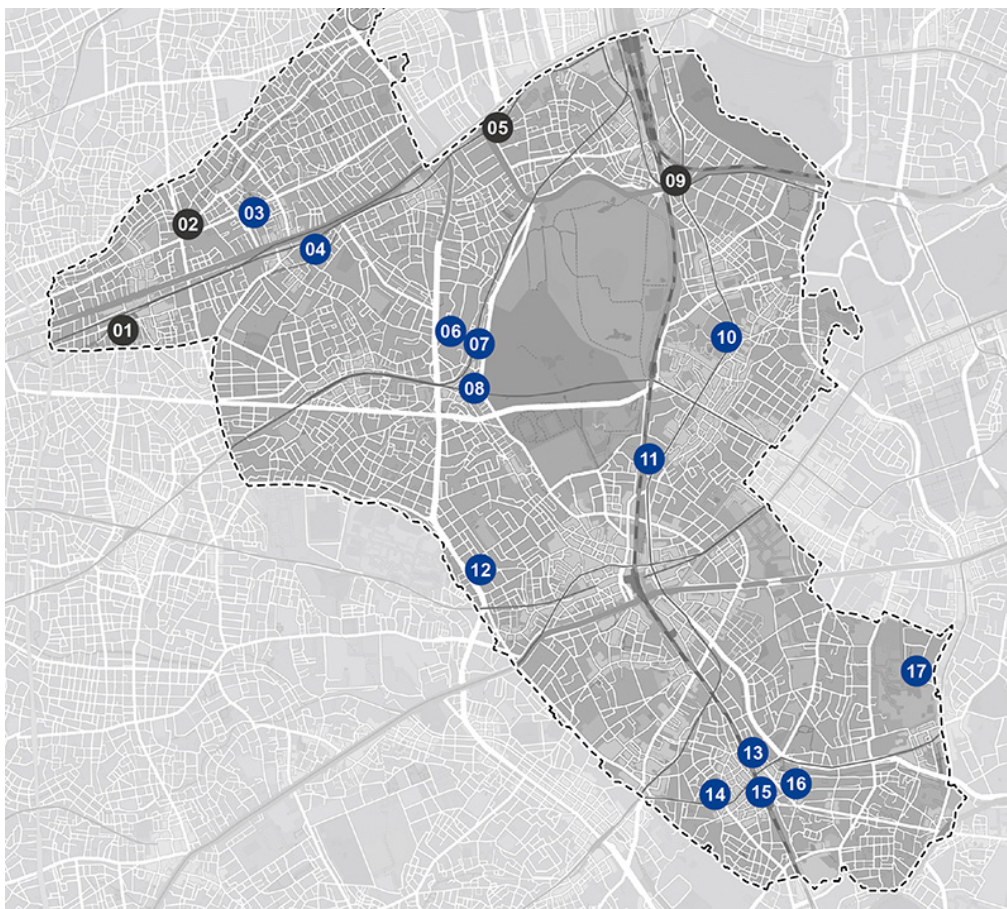


At night the facilities lights up the park like a beautiful lantern.

Toilet Overview

1. Sasazuka Greenway
Junko Kobayashi
Gondola Architects
Open : Mar. 10, 2023
2. Hatagaya
Tokyo DLX Design
Lab Miles Pennington
Open : Feb. 22, 2023
3. Nanago Dori Park
Kazoo Sato
Disruption Lab Team
Open : Aug. 12, 2021
4. Nishihara Itchome-Park
Takenosuke Sakakura
Open : Aug. 31, 2020
5. Nishisando
Sou Fujimoto
Open : Mar. 24, 2023
6. Yoyogi-Hachiman
Toyo Ito
Open : Jul. 16, 2021
7. Haru-no-Ogawa-Community Park
Shigeru Ban
Open : Aug. 5, 2020
8. Yoyogi Fukamachi-Mini Park
Shigeru Ban
Open : Aug. 5, 2020
9. Urasando
Marc Newson
Open : Jan. 20, 2023
10. Jingumae
NIGO®
Open : May 31, 2020
11. Jingu-Dori Park
Tadao Ando
Open : Sept. 7, 2020
12. Nabeshima Shoto-Park
Kengo Kuma
Open : June 24, 2021
13. Higashi Sancho-me
Nao Tamura
Open : Aug. 7, 2020
14. Ebisu Park
Masamichi Katayama
Wonderwall
Open : Aug. 5, 2020
15. Ebisu Station, West-Exit
Kashiwa Sato
Open : Jul. 15, 2021
16. Ebisu East Park
Fumihiko Maki
Open : Aug. 7, 2020
17. Hiroo East Park
Tomohito Ushiro
Open : Jul. 22, 2022

While the specifications of each toilet vary, wheelchair access is possible at all locations. Ostomate facilities are available at some locations. All toilets are equipped with Washlet.



A Guide to the Tokyo Toilets

Each of the 17 toilets is a unique reflection of its designer's vision.

1. Sasazuka Greenway – Junko Kobayashi

With rusted weathering steel cylinders and a bright yellow canopy, Kobayashi's design includes whimsical bunny graphics peeking through cut-outs. It's cheerful and practical, including child-friendly cubicles.



2. Hatagaya – Miles Pennington & DLX Design Lab

More than a restroom, this community hub doubles as an exhibition or meeting space. The spacious interior supports film screenings, art displays, and info kiosks, alongside male and unisex toilets.

3. Nanago Dori Park – Kazuo Sato

This futuristic hemispherical toilet is voice-activated, controlling everything from the door to ambient music. Its shape enhances airflow and over-turns the image of public toilets as dark and dirty.



4. Nishihara Itchome Park – Takenosuke Sakakura

These glowing lantern-like toilets light up the park at night, made from frosted glass imprinted with tree patterns. The unisex design aims to elevate the whole park's nighttime ambiance.



5. Nishisando – Sou Fujimoto

This white, sculptural restroom resembles a massive, shared sink. Taps at varying heights line an elongated basin, promoting handwashing for all ages in an open, flowing corridor.



6. Yoyogi-Hachiman – Toyo Ito

Inspired by mushrooms sprouting in the forest, Toyo Ito's trio of organic, mushroom-shaped cubicles offer a safe and naturalistic environment at the entrance to a shrine path.



7. Yoyogi Fukamachi Mini Park – Shigeru Ban

This facility uses transparent colored glass that turns opaque when occupied, emphasizing safety and modern design. The vibrant hues (orange, pink, purple) make it visually striking within the park.

8. Haru-no-Ogawa Community Park – Shigeru Ban

A counterpart to the Yoyogi facility, this version features cooler tones (blue and green) to blend with nature. Three cubicles divided by mirrored walls offer a balance of function and artful reflection.

9. Urasando – Marc Newson

Echoing traditional Japanese architecture, this concrete structure with a copper roof references temples and teahouses. Men's, women's, and accessible facilities are symmetrically arranged beneath an expressway.



10. Toilet, Jingumae – Nigo

Designed like a small storybook house, this toilet has a red roof, blue-framed windows, and chimney-like elements. Fashion designer Nigo infuses a nostalgic, domestic charm into this urban spot.



11. Amayadori, Jingu-Dori Park – Tadao Ando

“Rain shelter” in Japanese, Amayadori is a circular building wrapped in vertical metal louvres, allowing light and air to filter through while maintaining privacy. Nestled among cherry trees, it offers a serene presence.

12. Nabeshima Shoto Park – Kengo Kuma

Crafted from cedar wood, this set of five hut-like structures integrates into the park’s natural landscape. Accessible via a stepped path, they accommodate various users in a gentle, inclusive way.



13. Higashi Sanhome – Nao Tamura

Inspired by Origami (traditional Japanese gift wrapping), this triangular red structure stands as a symbol of hospitality and urgency. It houses separate male, female, and accessible toilets, launching the entire Tokyo Toilet project with a bold, visible design.

14. Modern Kawayu, Ebisu Park – Wonderwall

Referencing prehistoric kawayu (ancient toilets), this design uses board-marked concrete walls in a labyrinth-like structure. It includes gendered and unisex facilities, offering an earthy, tactile experience.



15. Toilet, Ebisu Station – Kashiwa Sato

With a facade of white aluminium louvres, this clean-lined, gender-neutral facility by graphic designer Sato reflects his minimalist branding sensibility, offering five bright, organized blocks.

16. Squid Toilet, Ebisu East Park – Fumihiko Maki

Nicknamed for its playful form, the Squid Toilet combines functionality with leisure, including a small courtyard and curved roof that matches the park's whimsical identity, known for an octopus-shaped slide.



17. Toilet, Hiroo East Park – Tomohito Ushiro

Ushiro's toilet is also a light art installation, with 7.9 billion LED pattern possibilities representing the global population. It has two square unisex cubicles with thoughtful family-friendly features.

Japan's Toilet Culture

Japan is world-renowned for its high-tech Washlet toilets, pioneered by TOTO. To commemorate its 100th anniversary, TOTO opened a \$60 million toilet museum in Kitakyushu, tracing the evolution of Japanese toilets from 19th-century squat styles to modern innovations. Exhibits include everything from General Douglas MacArthur's toilet to a biogas-powered motorbike. The Japanese government has also recognized the link between public sanitation improvements and gender equality, emphasizing that clean, accessible toilets are vital for promoting women's participation in public life and the workforce.

Maintenance

Maintenance is a cornerstone of the project's sustainability. Each facility is cleaned two to three times daily (more than double the standard for public toilets) ensuring they remain welcoming and pristine. Uniforms for cleaning staff, designed under the supervision of fashion designer NIGO®, have helped humanize the staff and encouraged positive interactions with the public.

As project leaders note: "Public restrooms can become dirty if they are not properly sanitized on a regular basis, but people find it hard to spoil something that has been carefully cleaned."





The toilets are cleaned two or three times a day by staff wearing uniforms designed under the supervision of the fashion designer

Perfect Day

To further promote the project, Koji Yanai invited acclaimed filmmaker Wim Wenders to Japan. The result was *Perfect Days* (2023), a full-length film following the daily life of a janitor, portrayed by Kōji Yakusho, who meticulously cleans these public toilets. The film explores themes of solitude, dignity, and the beauty of simple living. *Perfect Days* earned Yakusho the Best Actor Award at the Cannes Film Festival, and brought global attention to The Tokyo Toilet Project, highlighting the often-overlooked importance of humble public service.



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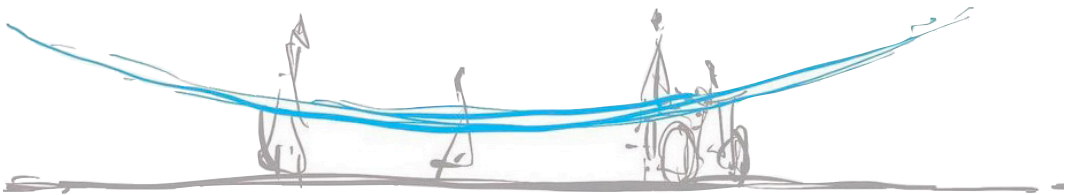
Each toilet is uniquely designed







The Tokyo Toilet Project challenges preconceived notions about public spaces by demonstrating that thoughtful design, meticulous maintenance, and social responsibility can elevate even the humblest parts of our cities. It embodies a vision where every element of the urban environment, no matter how small, contributes to a more beautiful, inclusive, and dignified society.



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Explore all 17 Tokyo Toilet projects featured in Wim Wenders' film Perfect Days. (2024, March 8). Dezeen. <https://www.dezeen.com/2024/03/08/tokyo-toilets-wim-wenders-perfect-days/>

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This book was inspired by my growing interest in Asian culture. I first encountered the Tokyo Toilet project through the film *Perfect Days*, a movie that I grew to really appreciate. The Tokyo Toilet project beautifully demonstrates the power of thoughtful design, showing how beauty and cleanliness can go hand in hand.

As I researched the project, one sentence from a cleaner stayed with me: "Our cleaning never used to be recognized. Now, users thank us. Some even bring us cold drinks on hot days like today."

That simple statement captures the heart of the project: true hospitality begins with genuine care and good design can create kindness and connection between people.



